

“From a personal preference perspective, I would choose an open source solution, any day”

What matters most to a CTO, you may wonder. Well, the answer is obvious—a good solution. Even better would be a good ‘cost-friendly’ solution. This is why open source technologies have been widely adopted by **Anoop Menon, CTO, redBus.in**. Menon is a die-hard fan of open source technologies and promotes these unabashedly across the firm. In an exclusive tête-à-tête with **Diksha P. Gupta** from **Open Source For You**, he shared redBus’ journey with open source. Excerpts:



Q What kind of open source technology deployments do you have at redBus.in?

Purely from the open source perspective, we use a lot of Java, which is a classic open source language, for both the platforms in our b2b business. Apart from that, we use a lot of open source NoSQL technology, which includes names like Redis, Cassandra and Neo4J graph database, the last of which we use when we want to bring out certain things quickly. We also keep experimenting with a lot of systems around caching and serving. We have played with technologies like MongoDB and Redis Cache. For queueing mechanisms, we use RabbitMQ, which are memory queues that allow us to process the data in a particular fashion. However, there is a small part of our business that still runs on proprietary technology, primarily around .NET.

Q Can you tell us something about the b2b platforms you have?

We have two b2b platforms. One is focused on the bus operators, that is, the businesses. We call it ‘redBus for Businesses’. The early name for this was BOGDS. This is basically the ticketing and inventory management system for the bus operators. They use our system to configure, manage their inventory and find out the route on which the bus travels. They can also use the platform to provide APIs to other partners. The second product we have is called Seat Seller. This is an agent business platform. If you were to travel, say, from Delhi to Jaipur, you can buy bus tickets in three ways. First, you can buy them online. Second, you could go to the bus stand, get into the bus and hope to get a seat, or, third, you can go a day early and buy a ticket at one of the agent shops. These are called travel agents or ticketing agents. We have a product called Seat Seller, which these agents use to book seats for customers who reach out to them for buying tickets. Those tickets are also bought off the redBus platform.

Q What technologies are these platforms based on?

Both BOGDS and Seat Seller use Java at the back-end. They use GWT for the framework and the front-end aspects. They also use the MySQL database and a bit of Redis for caching. This is the broad technology deployment structure at redBus.

Q redBus uses a lot of open source technologies. What are the advantages that you derive by using these?

Just to clarify, redBus started off by building everything on .NET a long time back. However, during the course of the last three to four years, we have seen large adoption of open source technologies. Primarily, open source gives us the flexibility to do things fast. If I were to use a particular proprietary technology, I would have to either build every component on my own, or purchase some licensed software. In the first case, I would require a lot of manpower, time and resources. I too was supposed to buy some licensed software, but the cost is usually exorbitant. This is one big advantage that open source brings to the table for redBus.

So, if I want to deliver something new, whether it is a new piece of technology or a process, open source allows me to do it really fast. If a particular process would otherwise take weeks or